Entry 003

May 24, 1984

Got the scope loose! Almost lost a thumbnail doing it, worth it. Spins all the way around now, which means I can finally look at the loons properly. Which I DID. Briefly. Then I spent the next hour looking at the neighbor's house across the pond instead, which I did not plan and am a little embarrassed about, except nobody will ever read this so who cares.

It's not my fault. It's just where the scope wants to point. Swing it left from the loons and you're looking right at his back deck and the boat shed underneath. His whole back end, basically. From the road you can't see any of it, the hill hides it, but from my dumb little blind it's like having a front row seat.

His name is Ray. I know because the mailman yelled "RAY, GOT A PACKAGE!" across the water and he came walking down. Big. Not fat, just BUILT, like they made him from a different batch than the rest of us. Has a dog? Maybe? Saw something dog-shaped once, could've been a bush.

He has coffee on the deck at seven every morning, chipped blue mug, and stands there ten minutes just looking at the water. I know that's weird to say but I kind of like it. Two strangers both looking at the same pond without knowing about each other. Very peaceful. Very not-creepy as long as I don't think too hard about how it started.

His boots live outside the door, which tells me he gave up on the mud a long time ago. And his laundry!! Work shirts, undershirts, one pair of jeans darned at the knee by somebody with more patience than skill. And then Tuesday: a SLIP. Pale blue. And some other things I'm fairly sure were not his.

So there's a Mrs. Ray. Or an A Ray. I haven't seen her once. Just the wash. Like a ghost who does her own laundry. I could've gone my whole life without knowing this but now I have to know.

NOTE: stop checking. You're not that kind of person. You're forty-six, you have a perfectly nice kiln. Go make a mug.

Okay, one more look tomorrow. For the loons.

Opened the second bottle. Just to see what it was like with the cheese.

[added later · different pen, handwriting loose and slanting off the lines]

11:40?? pm. Ray. out the bottom door. WOMAN. i saw a woman. in the doorway of the lower garage with the light behind her. barefoot?? something pale. nightgown. he put his hand on her back and let her stand there a minute. like letting a dog out. she looked at the pond. i swear she looked right at the pond. then he walked her BACK IN. gentle. gentle but fast. and he locked it. big key. from the OUTSIDE. i saw it. he put the key in his pocket. someone is locked in. SOMEONE IS LOCKED IN THERE. call someone. who. frank no. lisa no. the sheriff. what do i say. a woman in a nightgown. he's a nice man. he has a mug.

May 25, morning

I'm writing this sober. I want that noted. Mostly sober. Mostly.

I woke up on the couch at nine with my mouth like carpet. The good wine glass was in pieces on the kitchen floor, and I've got a cut on my heel I don't remember getting. The second bottle's empty. That's both of them, in five days. The pill bottle was on the counter with the cap off. I took one. Maybe two. I don't remember taking either. I do remember the orange sticker, and thinking, it's fine, I'm only a LITTLE drunk.

Frank's barn coat was on the porch, soaking, and there's mud on the steps. I think I went down to the blind in the dark. I don't remember going.

So. Did I see a woman? Honestly? I don't know. I know what I wrote. I know what the writing looks like. It looks like somebody who's drunk.

Here's what I figured out sitting on the kitchen floor with a dustpan. Twenty-six years, Frank counted my glasses. Not out loud. He'd just look. One at dinner, fine. Two and there was a little pause. I never learned to stop on my own because nobody ever let me practice. And then my first night here I made coffee at 8 p.m. and nothing happened, and I thought: well, what ELSE can I do that nothing will happen about. I'm not blaming him. I'm saying I walked through a door that wasn't locked anymore and I went a lot farther than I meant to.

No wine till next Friday. Pills back up in the cabinet behind the Band-Aids. Carried both empties down to the root cellar (found a trapdoor under the pantry rug last week, eight feet square, cool, a little creepy, perfect for things I don't want to look at) so I'd stop seeing them on the counter.

I should rip out the page with the scribbling. I'm leaving it. Because if it's true, somebody should have written it down, and I happen to be the person who did, drunk or not.